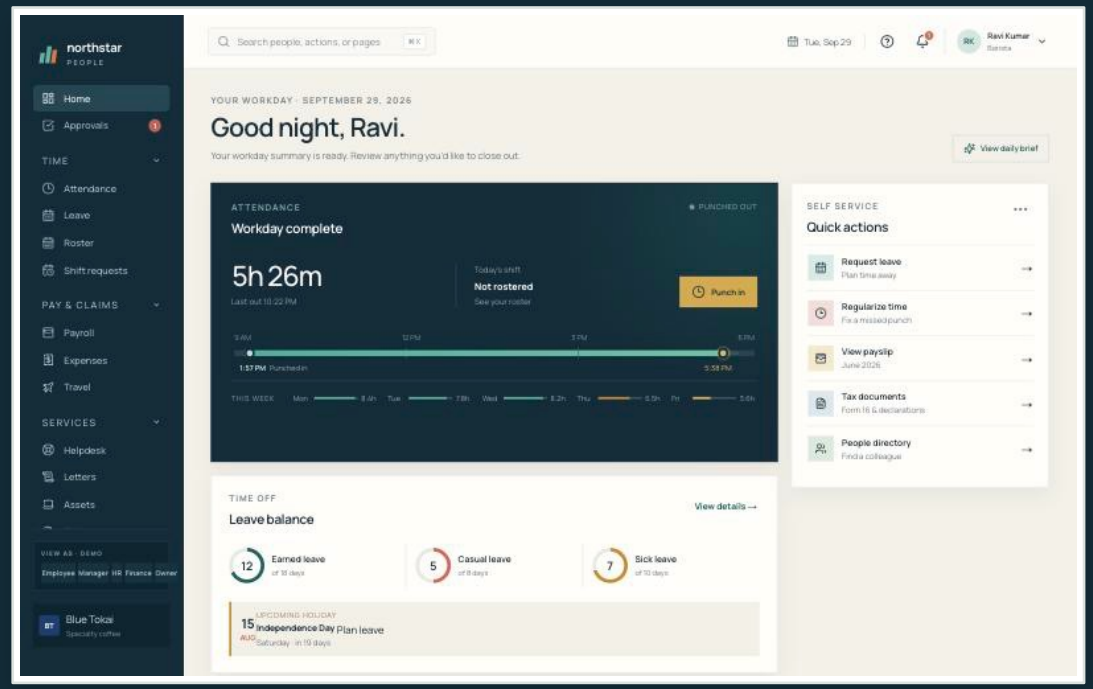
NORTHSTAR PEOPLE

Our own HR platform for Blue Tokai, Got Tea & Suchali's

A proposal to move off PeopleStrong in phases — starting with a low-risk pilot.



For HR leadership review · September 2026

The proposal in one slide

We built a complete HR platform that we own. We want to prove it on one brand before replacing PeopleStrong.

3

brands on one platform

each fully isolated

25+

HR modules working

web, API and database

2

apps

web + iOS/Android

0

licence fee per employee

we pay only to run it

The ask

Approve a pilot on one smaller brand: run attendance, leave and the service desk live, and run payroll in parallel with PeopleStrong for two cycles. Decide on the full switch only after the numbers match.

Everything HR runs today, in one place

Built and working end to end — records, approvals, notifications and audit trail included.

Core HR
Employee records, directory, org chart, CSV import, documents

Time
GPS + selfie attendance, biometric devices, leave, roster, corrections

Pay
India payroll (PF, ESI, PT, TDS), payslips, expenses with receipt scan, travel

Service desk
Helpdesk with SLAs, HR letters, assets, exit and full-and-final

Talent
Onboarding checklists, courses & certificates, hiring & referrals, KPIs

Engagement
Surveys & eNPS, quick polls, recognition wall, announcements

Insight
16 analytics reports, group dashboard, risk & compliance checks

Platform
Multi-brand, company SSO, roles & permissions, audit, automations

Employees get a fast, simple app

Web and a native iOS/Android app (React Native) on the same data.

Punch in where you work

Location checked against the café's geofence; a live selfie with blink check when outside the site.

Snap a bill, get a claim

Receipt scan fills merchant, date, amount and GST; duplicates are flagged automatically.

Payslips in your pocket

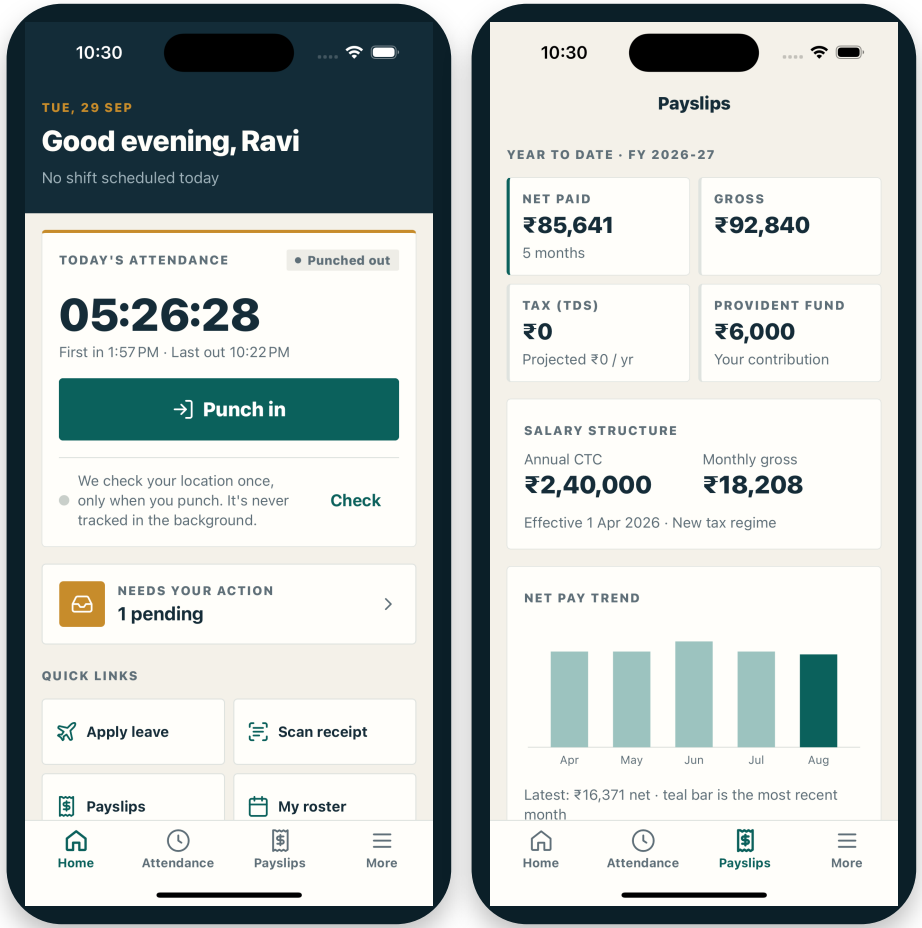
Year-to-date pay, PF, tax projection and every payslip, shareable as a document.

Leave, roster, approvals

Apply leave, see this week's shifts; managers approve from the phone.

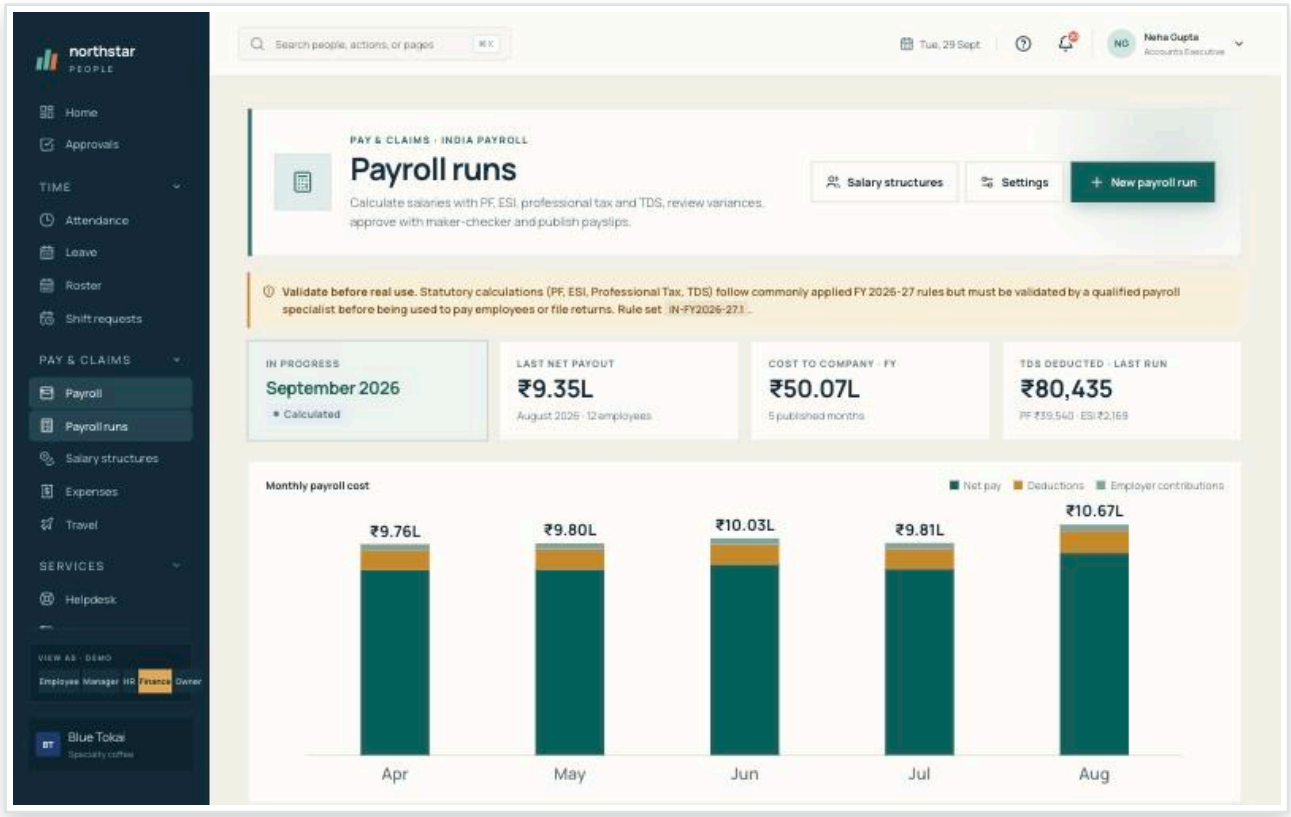
Push notifications

Approvals, payslips and roster changes arrive instantly, with quiet hours.



Payroll that finance can trust

India payroll engine with statutory rules, controls and every file finance needs.



Statutory rules

PF (₹15,000 ceiling), ESI (≤ ₹21,000), professional tax by state, TDS projection — versioned rule set FY 2026-27.

Maker-checker

The person who submits a run can't approve it. Variance flags for >10% pay changes, missing structures, new joiners.

Files out

Bank transfer, PF ECR, ESI, PT summary, payroll register, Tally XML journal — reconciled to run totals.

Employees see it

Published payslips with full breakdown, on web and mobile.

Honest caveat: statutory calculations must be validated by a payroll specialist and matched against PeopleStrong for two cycles before we pay anyone from it.

One platform, every brand — kept apart

Blue Tokai, Got Tea and Suchali's each run as a separate organisation; the owner sees them side by side.

Data stays inside each brand

Enforced by the database itself (row-level security), not just by screens.

Own look and login link

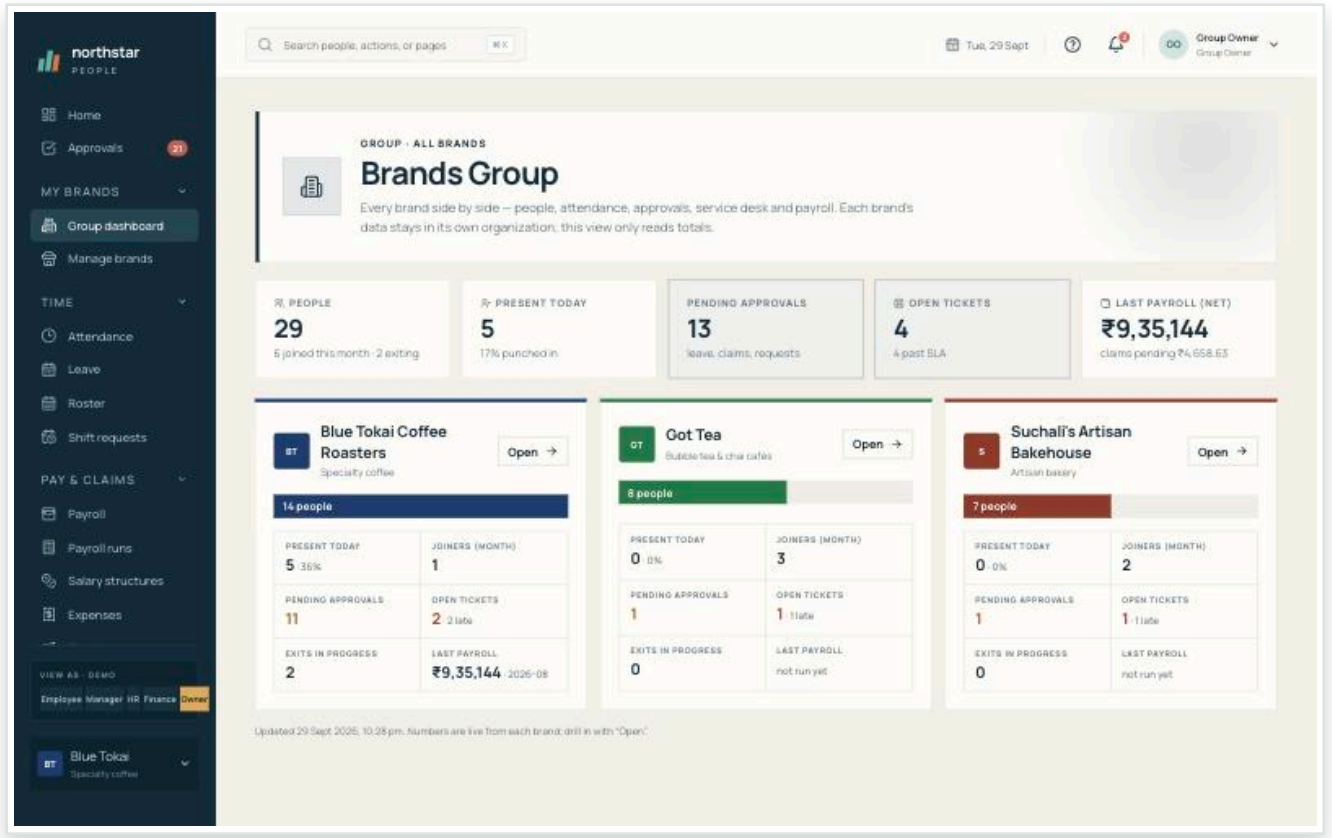
Each brand has its colours, logo and sign-in page — employees never see other brands.

New brand in a minute

Super admin adds a brand, switches modules on/off and appoints its HR admin.

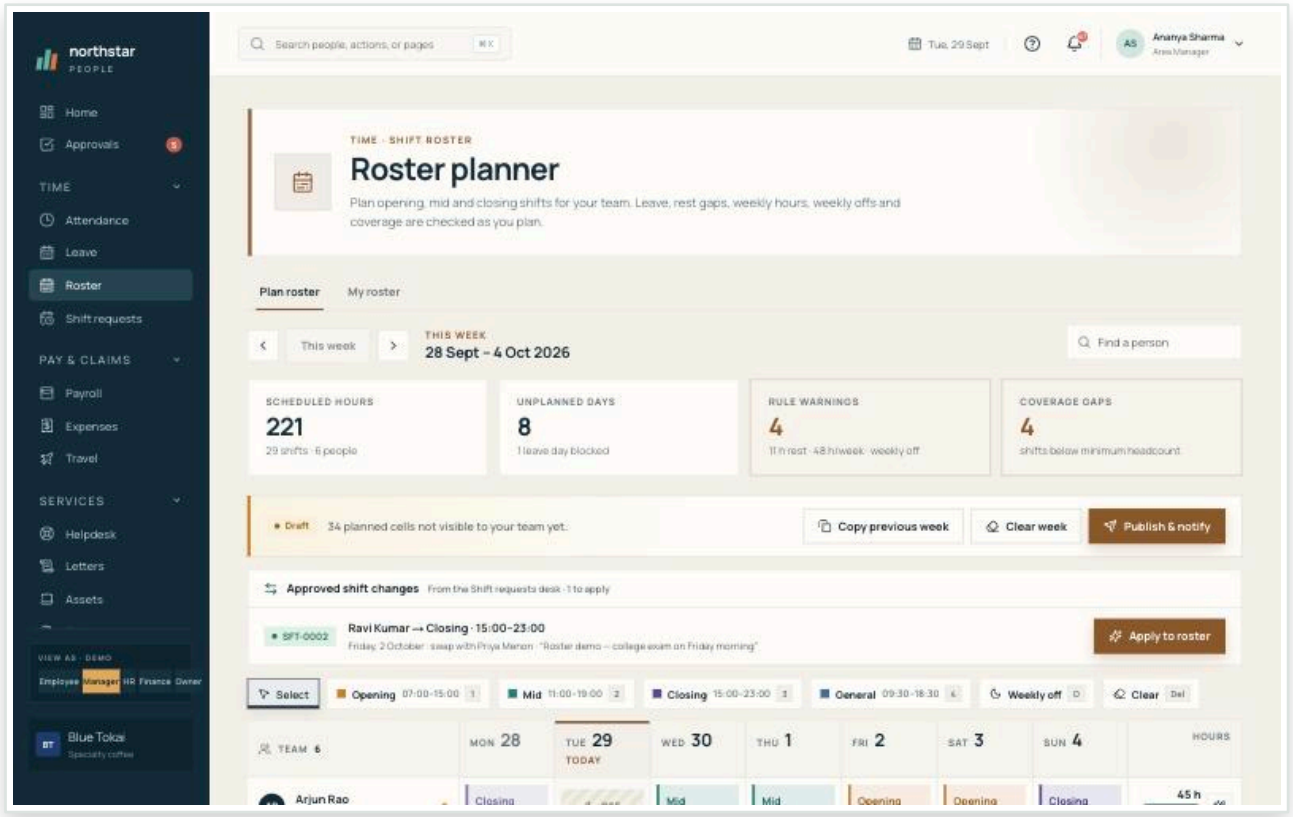
Group dashboard

Headcount, attendance, approvals, tickets and payroll for all brands in one view.



Built for how our cafés actually run

Shift-based teams, many outlets, and attendance that can't be gamed.



Roster planner with labour rules

Warns on 48+ hours a week, under 11 h rest, missing weekly off and thin coverage before publishing.

No buddy punching

Geofence, live selfie with blink check, and review of punches from the same phone or impossible travel.

Works with existing devices

ZKTeco / eSSL biometric terminals push punches straight in.

Shift swaps in two taps

Approved swap requests apply to the roster automatically.

Security: what's in place, what's left

An internal white-box review found 22 issues (1 critical, 2 high); fixes are in progress. No system is unbreakable — we monitor.

In place today

- Brand data isolated by the database (row-level security on a least-privilege role)
- Company single sign-on — MFA enforced by our identity provider
- Append-only audit trail: no one can edit or delete history
- Rate limiting, security headers, strict file-upload checks
- Security Center: live readiness checks and blocked-request monitoring
- Maker-checker on payroll approval and bank payouts

Before go-live

- Close the remaining review findings (e.g. retire the old legacy API, second approval for bank-detail changes)
- Encrypt PAN and bank details at rest
- Independent penetration test by a CERT-In empanelled auditor
- Production hosting in India with encrypted backups and point-in-time recovery
- Upgrade framework versions flagged by the dependency audit

Owning vs renting — the trade-offs

PeopleStrong is a mature product. The question is fit and control, not features alone.

Area	PeopleStrong (rent)	Northstar (own)
Data ownership	Held by the vendor; export on request	Our own database, in our cloud account
Fit to our processes	Configure within the product	Change anything — roster rules, selfie policy, forms
Multiple brands	Extra setup / licences	Built in; new brand at no extra licence
Cost model	Per-employee licence, rises with headcount	Hosting + upkeep; flat as we grow
Statutory updates	Vendor maintains	We must maintain (named owner + yearly review)
Support & uptime	Vendor SLA	Internal owner + on-call developer

Amber = responsibilities that move to us. They're manageable, but they're real and must be staffed.

What we'd save — fill in our real numbers

Replace the blanks with the PeopleStrong contract and a hosting quote before this goes to finance.

A · PeopleStrong today

Licence: ₹ ____ per employee / month

× ____ employees × 12

+ add-on modules: ₹ ____

+ yearly price increase: ____ %

= ₹ _____ per year

−

B · Running Northstar

Cloud hosting (DB, app, storage): ₹ ____

SMS / email / push: ₹ ____

Upkeep: ____ developer (part-time)

Yearly pentest + payroll review: ₹ ____

= ₹ _____ per year

=

Yearly saving

₹ _____

Grows with every new outlet and brand, because there's no per-employee licence.

Also count one-time costs honestly: data migration, a parallel payroll period and staff training.

Risks and how we handle them

The plan is built so that no employee is affected until each risk is closed.

Risk	How we handle it
Payroll mistakes	Two parallel cycles matched to the rupee + payroll specialist sign-off before first live run
Statutory changes (PF, ESI, PT, TDS)	Named owner; versioned rule set; yearly review with our CA / compliance partner
Data migration from PeopleStrong	Import employee, leave-balance and salary data from exports; reconciliation report per brand
Security	Close review findings, external pentest, backups with restore drills, Security Center monitoring
Support after go-live	Internal HRIS owner + developer on-call; helpdesk inside the product for issues
Adoption	Mobile app first, short training per role, pilot feedback before the next brand

Rollout plan

Indicative timings — we move to the next phase only when the previous one is signed off.

1

Pilot

6–8 weeks

One smaller brand (Got Tea or Suchali's). Attendance, leave, helpdesk live. Payroll in parallel for 2 cycles.

2

Smaller brands live

4–6 weeks

Payroll switched after sign-off. Expenses, onboarding, learning, surveys turned on.

3

Blue Tokai

8–10 weeks

Outlet-by-outlet move with biometric devices connected; parallel payroll again.

4

Exit PeopleStrong

at renewal

Final data export and archive; licence not renewed.

What we need from HR

Four decisions to start the pilot.

1

Pick the pilot brand

and a named HR owner for it

2

Share the PeopleStrong contract

cost, renewal date and data-export terms

3

Line up a payroll specialist

to validate the statutory rules and sign off the parallel runs

4

Approve a small budget

production hosting, external pentest, training

Live demo available now — each brand has its own sign-in page, plus a super-admin console for all brands.